CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Reading Guide

Compiled by the Spaced Research Ledger

Last updated: 2026-09-01

The CA/Browser Forum decides what a publicly trusted certificate may contain, how its holder must be checked, and how long it may live. Its decisions reach almost every encrypted connection on the internet, and they are made in public by a body most people have never heard of. This collection follows that body and the browser root programs that enforce its rules [1].

The collection has five parts. Every part stands on its own, and every statement carries a numbered citation to a public source. Where two sources disagree, the disagreement is reported rather than resolved.

1. How To Read a Forum Decision

One distinction governs this whole subject, and getting it wrong is the most common error in reporting on the Forum.

A ballot that passes its vote is not yet a rule. The Forum's decisions move through five states, and only the last two bind anyone.

A ballot is first **proposed**, drafted and argued in a discussion period of at least seven days. It then enters a **voting** period of seven days. If it passes it is **adopted**, which starts a 30-day intellectual property review. Only after that review does the text **publish** into a numbered version of a guideline. A separate effective date decides when it is **in force**, and that date is often a year or more after publication.

The practical consequence is that three different true statements can be made about the same ballot, and only one of them means certificate authorities must do anything. This collection states the stage every time. Where a requirement has a future effective date, that date is given.

The unit that carries through all of it is the ballot identifier. Those identifiers are stable and prefixed by working group, so SC is the Server Certificate group, CSC is Code Signing, SMC is S/MIME, and FORUM is Forum-level governance [2].

2. The Parts

Each part covers one working group or one enforcement layer.

Part 1, Server Certificate Working Group. The busiest group, governing the certificates that secure websites. It covers the ballots and document versions, domain control validation, and certificate profiles including the schedule that is cutting certificate lifetimes toward 47 days by 2029. This is the part to read first if you only read one.

Part 2, Code Signing Working Group. The rules for certificates that sign software. A smaller group, and the source of a useful warning about reading a standards body correctly, because two of the Forum's own pages disagree about which version is current.

Part 3, S/MIME Working Group. The rules for certificates that sign and encrypt email. The youngest document set, and the one place in the Forum where post-quantum algorithms are already permitted in published requirements.

Part 4, Public Trust Programs. The enforcement layer. Mozilla, Google, Microsoft and Apple each decide who is actually trusted, and their policies routinely demand more than the Forum does, earlier. This part also covers the incident and distrust record.

Part 5, Revocation and Transparency. The two mechanisms for recovering from a certificate that should not exist. Revocation is being replaced rather than repaired, and transparency is undergoing its first architectural change since it was standardized.

3. What This Collection Does Not Cover

Scope boundaries, stated so that an absence is not read as a finding.

Post-quantum algorithm standardization belongs to a separate collection. This collection records what the Forum permits in a certificate, not how the underlying algorithms are chosen or specified.

Three of the Forum's areas are configured but not yet researched, so they carry no content here. Those are the Network Security Working Group, Forum governance including bylaws and intellectual property policy, and the referenced standards and audit regimes that the guidelines depend on. They will join the collection when they are activated and carry data.

Several named gaps sit inside the parts that do exist. The Validation Subcommittee's own minutes were not read for Part 1. Timestamping and key protection requirements were not covered in Part 2. The text of the post-quantum ballot was not read for Part 3. Each part records its own gaps in the relevant section, rather than leaving them silent.

About This Report

The Spaced Research Ledger is an automated system that gathers claims from live public sources, checks each one against its origin, and records every disagreement instead of merging it. Every stage runs on a different AI model, drawn from three to four systems across competing labs, so no single model both finds a claim and judges it. The Spaced Research Ledger is designed and maintained by Ridley DiSiena.

Sources

1. CA/Browser Forum. https://cabforum.org/ (2026-09-01)
2. All CA/Browser Forum Ballots. https://cabforum.org/ballots/ (2026-09-01)